

SELF-LOADING PISTOLS (1981–90)

Self-loading pistols from this period all display the squared profile that has become the accepted norm for these weapons. Structurally, they increasingly incorporated components made of lightweight metal alloys or synthetic polymers. The use of the latter initially caused unease among both users and law enforcement officials. Users feared that parts made entirely of polymers would not withstand the stresses generated during firing, while the police were worried that such arms would be invisible to metal detectors. But these concerns proved to be unfounded—the so-called “plastic pistols” were here to stay.



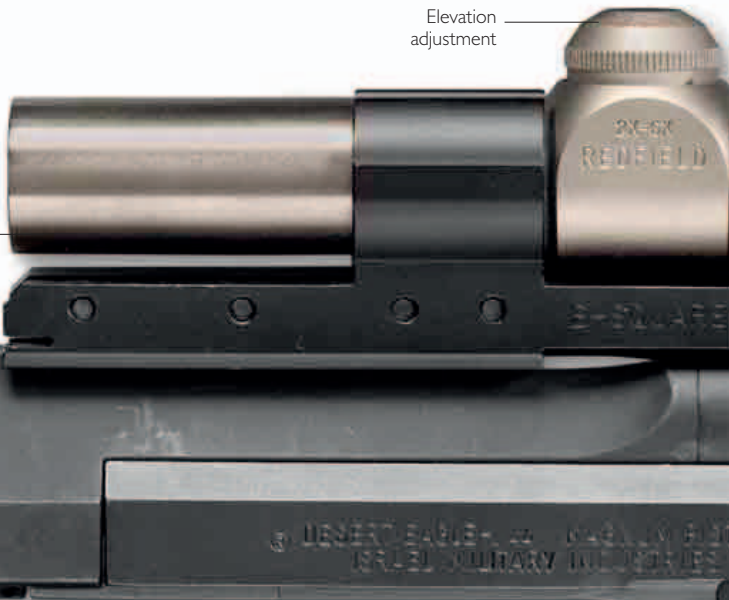
Housing for recoil spring and laser target indicator

Enlarged trigger guard for gloved hands

Butt houses 17-round detachable box magazine

► GLOCK 17
Date 1982
Origin Austria
Barrel 4½in (11.4cm)
Caliber 9mm Parabellum

Designed by Gaston Glock, this pistol utilized a polymer frame and had metal parts treated with a proprietary formula finish that prevented surface oxidation. It also had three independent safety locking systems, including the Browning locking system (see p. 270), that prevented accidental firing. Though treated with skepticism when introduced, the Glock is now used worldwide by police forces and military personnel.



Elevation adjustment

Optical sight

Interchangeable barrel

Muzzle brake



Foresight

Stamped slide

Grooves allow slide to be gripped

Decocking device

Internal barrel bushing

Magazine catch

Butt houses detachable box magazine

► SIG-SAUER 9MM P226
Date 1984
Origin Switzerland
Barrel 4¼in (11cm)
Caliber 9mm Parabellum

Developed in Switzerland by SIG, the SIG-Sauer is manufactured by J. P. Sauer and Sohn in Germany and in the U.S. Early versions had stamped slides but later production examples have slides milled from steel billets. It features a decocking device that allows the hammer to be safely lowered with a loaded cartridge in the chamber for carrying, so that the pistol is ready for immediate use when it is loaded.

▲ IMI DESERT EAGLE
Date 1983
Origin Israel
Barrel 10in (25.4cm)
Caliber .44in Magnum (as shown here)

Unlike almost all other self-loading pistols, the Desert Eagle, made by Israel Military Industries (IMI), was gas-operated (see p. 305), and of modular design. Its standard frame was able to accept sets of components for different ammunition, from .357in Magnum to .5in Action Express (AE), and barrels of different lengths.